

APPARENT



He travels to the countryside to discover the other India. He defies traditional party structures and runs a parallel organisation. Still he is not ready as a desperate Congress waits for a saviour.

ON SPEED DIAL:
The party wants the young scion to turn on his charisma

him to explain himself. And sometimes he does not even bother to hide it. When the media was tipped off about his visit to a Youth Congress conclave in the capital recently, an angry Rahul walked past the waiting cameras, the same ones he had wooed a day earlier for the cricket match he had hosted in Amethi. But that was when he had needed the media. Later, he demanded to know who had tipped them off about his presence. This is not the way his father would have handled it. While Rajiv Gandhi would have charmed the media with just a wave, even the reticent Sonia Gandhi is now savvy enough to smile away uncomfortable questions. With the arrogance of the chosen one, Rahul knows all too well that both the limelight and prime ministership are his for the asking. So why should he bother trying?

There is one problem though. He is not bringing in the votes, whether in Mayawati's caste-conscious Uttar Pradesh or Gujarat, where the vote is polarised. He also failed to curb anti-incumbency in Himachal Pradesh and could not swing the election in favour of the Congress in Karnataka. And there is a general election round the corner. Despite his below-average electoral appeal, Rahul is the best pin-up for Brand Congress against the 80-year-old L.K. Advani. But Rahul is in no hurry to grasp at prime ministership. He knows all too well that he has age on his side. What he needs is experience. Says first-time Congress MP Milind Deora, "Politics is like the stockmarket and Rahul is a long-term investor. He is not a speculator playing for short-term gains."

His focus is on the

youth and the downtrodden. But he needs more than photo-ops in tribal backdrops to win the Dalit vote and to undo the impact of the late Kanshi Ram's bicycle tours in the bylanes of Uttar Pradesh, where the BSP founder had instilled caste pride in the outcasts. For Rahul, eating *puri*, *aloo* and pickles at a village hamlet and sleeping in the open on the best *charpai* a village can offer may be an adventure. His bedazzled hosts, for whom this is a way of life, know he is merely passing by. The very next day, the young scion is seen at a cricket match, wearing a black polo T-shirt and linen trousers, rubbing shoulders with the glitterati. How then does he expect to empathise with someone who does not even know if he will be able to feed his family the next meal? After lunching with friends at an exclusive Japanese restaurant in a five-star hotel in the capital, he wonders how many mouths could have been fed instead. He bemoans the lack of inner-party democracy when his own nomination is an assured dynastic privilege. He has figured out the disconnect between the two Indias. There seems to be a disconnect between himself and the shirtless of the other India, too.

It has been eight months since Rahul finally agreed to take over as general secretary. In keeping with the

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family tradition, like his father and his uncle, he took charge of the youth wings. Under his leadership, professionals are being wooed to do away with the flash-cash-and-dash image, Rahul, who himself belongs to the SMS generation, has also encouraged the use of SMS and e-mail in recruiting new members. Says Sachin Pilot, the